

Project Proposal:

Redevelopment of the Sanford B. Ladd School

Into a Community Resource Hub

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Project Overview

The Sanford B. Ladd School, a 56,000-square-foot historic structure that has remained vacant since its closure in 2010, represents a significant opportunity for community revitalization in the Oak Park neighborhood. This proposal outlines a plan to convert the building into a community-run resource hub offering job training, essential services, educational programming, family and child enrichment activities, and a community garden. The project aims to restore a long-neglected public asset while creating sustainable, community-driven economic and social value.

Problem Statement

Residents in the surrounding neighborhoods face persistent challenges, including limited access to job training, food insecurity, insufficient childcare and youth programming, and a lack of safe, accessible gathering spaces. The absence of a centralized community resource center forces families to travel long distances for basic services, creating barriers for those without reliable transportation. The prolonged vacancy of the Sanford B. Ladd School contributes to neighborhood disinvestment and reduces opportunities for community cohesion. Without intervention, the building will continue to deteriorate, and the neighborhood will lose a critical opportunity for long-term improvement.

Proposed Solution

This project proposes transforming the Sanford B. Ladd School into a multi-service community hub operated by neighborhood residents. The renovated facility will include:

- A job and career development center
- A food and clothing pantry
- Classrooms for GED preparation, trade skills, and community education
- Maker spaces and computer labs
- A large event and meeting space in the former gymnasium
- A community garden on the adjacent elevated field
- Family and child enrichment programming, offered through partnerships with Kansas City Parks and Recreation or the Kansas City Public Library system

The operational model emphasizes community ownership through a cooperative or community land trust structure. Skilled trades (HVAC, electrical, plumbing) will be contracted, while unskilled labor will be hired from within the neighborhood, creating immediate employment opportunities and strengthening community investment in the project.

Project Scope

The scope includes full renovation of the building's core and shell, interior fit-out for program spaces, installation of modern mechanical systems, and construction of the community garden.

Key deliverables include:

- Renovated, code-compliant building
- Fully equipped job center and computer labs

- Pantry and donation distribution area
- Classrooms and multipurpose spaces
- Accessible event and meeting areas
- Twenty or more raised garden beds with irrigation
- Governance structure, staffing plan, and volunteer recruitment
- Partnerships for youth and family programming

Administrative development, including recruitment of educators, volunteers, program coordinators, and governance members, will run concurrently with the physical renovation to ensure operational readiness at project completion.

Timeline

The project follows a realistic 36–38-month schedule aligned with public-sector construction and historic preservation requirements (LocalCode, n.d.).

Phase 1: Pre-Development (12–18 months)

Community engagement, governance formation, grant applications (HUD CDBG, CCED Sales Tax, EDA Capital Grants), environmental reviews, and architectural design.

Phase 2: Building Renovation (18–20 months)

Environmental abatement, exterior repairs, installation of major infrastructure systems, interior finishes, and final inspections. Comparable redevelopment data for the Ladd School estimates a 19-month construction period (Drexel Tech, 2026).

Phase 3: Community Garden (2–3 months, parallel)

Site preparation, raised bed construction, irrigation installation, and community planting.

Administrative & Program Development (parallel to Phases 1–3)

Recruitment of educators, program staff, volunteers, and governance members; development of operational policies; partnership agreements with Parks & Recreation and the public library; and creation of program curricula.

Final Milestone

Grand opening at Month 36–38, aligned with the first garden harvest and launch of job center and family programming.

Required Resources

The project requires a combination of professional and community labor:

- **Skilled labor:** project foreman, HVAC technicians, electricians, plumbers
- **Community labor:** demolition support, landscaping, garden installation, interior preparation
- **Professional services:** architectural firm, environmental consultants, grant compliance specialists
- **Governance:** elected community steering committee
- **Program partners:** Kansas City Parks and Recreation, Kansas City Public Library

This hybrid model reduces labor costs, increases community ownership, and aligns with best practices for community-driven development.

Budget Estimate

Based on comparable redevelopment data and preliminary estimates (Drexel Tech, 2026; LocalCode, n.d.):

- Building renovation: **\$8.4M–\$11.2M**
- Interior fit-out: **\$1.5M–\$2.5M**
- Community garden: **\$4,500–\$7,000**
- **Total startup cost: \$10M–\$13.7M**

Funding will be sourced through federal and local grants that support community facilities and neighborhood revitalization, including HUD Community Development Block Grants, the Central City Economic Development Sales Tax program, and the Economic Development Administration’s Public Works and EAA programs (City of Kansas City, Missouri, 2024; U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, 2023; U.S. Economic Development Administration, 2023).

Expected Impact

The project will generate significant social, economic, and community benefits:

- Creation of local jobs during construction and operation
- Increased access to job training and career development
- Reduction in food insecurity through pantry and garden programs
- Expanded educational and enrichment opportunities for youth and families
- Strengthened community cohesion through shared governance
- Revitalization of a historic neighborhood landmark

By converting a long-vacant building into a vibrant community asset, the project directly supports neighborhood stability and long-term resilience.

Conclusion

The redevelopment of the Sanford B. Ladd School offers a high-impact, feasible, and community-aligned solution to longstanding neighborhood challenges. The project scores strongly across key selection criteria, including strategic alignment, community benefit, feasibility, and long-term sustainability. With a realistic timeline, clear scope, and secured funding pathways, this proposal represents a transformative opportunity to reinvest in the Oak Park community and restore a historic building as a center of shared growth and support.

References

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